Underemployment was significant as a factor in economics when you were talking about an excess number of people dependent on agriculture. In the past decade, there is a clear move out of agriculture into other skills. That is why, when the e-Shram portal was launched, much to the surprise of the ministry itself, there were more than 200 trades that were registered in which people were engaged, and which the National Skill Development Council is working on now. So, underemployment is never the issue when self-employment comes in. Today's economy is moving towards people doing their own work, it's all about being entrepreneurial.



Q. Another big election issue is high prices. Government figures show that inflation is under control, but when the common man goes out to buy a basket of goods, they find the prices high. Is there more that could be done to rein in inflation?

On inflation, my answer is that any amount of effort, because of the nature of goods that come into the market and that make it to the poor man's thali, will always be inadequate. And that's not to say I wash my hands of (the problem) there. Not at all. Whether it's onions or potatoes or edible oil, whether it's making sure that vegetables reach in time, whether it is pulses that we don't produce adequately, importing them in time and in bulk. At least, 5-6 years ago, because of the incentives given, many of the farmers moved to producing pulses. But after that, there was a disinterest because of procurement- or price-related issues. In this, state governments also play a role. Now, after a point, the imported inflation also adds to your burden. Edible oil prices are fluctuating. Crude, of course. Post-Covid, urea prices reached Rs 3,000 a bag. A bag that a farmer buys at Rs 298 is completely imported. I had to highlight this to the PM and he was very clear. He said you will import. There shall not be a shortage, despite the price you will import and the burden will be on our government. It was a clear instruction. So, we are managing that input cost and making sure the fuel, which is a big component, is also maintained. Because of the leadership of Prime Minister Modi, we didn't fear sanctions and could still get imported crude from Russia, after the Ukraine war, at a discount. We kept national interests in mind and didn't hold back.

"At least now you can track down black money and take action. Look at how the ED and CBI are going after stacks and stacks of money kept in homes or toilets or in farmhouses"

Q. The advantages of Russian oil are now waning in some sense, and fresh disruptions are happening in West Asia. What will be their impact?

I think it's three wars as well as the major disruption in the Red Sea. There is going to be great volatility, including in the movement of freight on the high seas. All countries, including India, will have to brace for these uncertainties. Crude prices have breached 90 dollars a barrel (on April 18 and 19). In spite of Covid, in spite of so many wars, in spite of disruption in the high seas, in spite of the China-US problem, we are still managing inflation and keeping it well within the limit.

Q. Experts are pointing to a K-shaped growth in the economy where the rich are getting richer, and the poor, poorer. Shouldn't it be a matter of concern?

Just look at the way your GST collection is going. GST is not in its favourable grade structure yet. We will have to do some work on rate rationalisation. We will also have to look at the direct tax collection. There was a time when people said GST is earning more than direct taxation. That's not true. Direct taxation is contributing much, much more now and that's how it should be. What Prime Minister Modi's economic vision is is to make everyone create wealth for themselves. Like there's a proverb in Tamil—*viralukketha veekkam*—the size of the finger will determine the quantum of swelling it